



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Imago Dei Neighborhood School

School Website: <https://imagodeirichmond.org/>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

SCL MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because SCL requires adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: **CLASSICAL**

Executive Summary

Imago Dei Neighborhood School (Richmond, VA 23222) presents a strongly Christian, liberal-arts oriented program with clear classical influences, but with notable gaps relative to a traditional classical model. Public materials from the school emphasize gospel-centered, holistic Christian formation, a robust liberal-arts framework, and a cross-curricular, experiential pedagogy. Evidence of a theological grounding, formation-in-character, and a partnership with families is explicit. However, explicit claims about core classical elements like the Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; quadrivium), Great Books and the Great Conversation, and the full deployment of Socratic pedagogy (especially in upper grades) are not consistently stated in the public materials. The school shows strong alignment with Element 1 (Religious & Metaphysical Foundations) and Element 2 (Purpose & Goal), modest alignment with Element 3 (Curriculum) and Element 4 (Pedagogy), and partial alignment with Element 5 (Faculty) and Element 6 (Parents & Community). Taken together, the aggregate classification is Somewhat Classical, with several needle-moving opportunities to strengthen explicit classical markers.

Key signal elements from the school's public materials include:

- A gospel-centered, liberal-arts approach rooted in Christian formation (Evidence: "gospel-centered, liberal arts education"; Bible-based instruction; core commitments; mission language).
- Explicit emphasis on virtue, wisdom, and formation in the whole child (Evidence: "cultivation of wisdom and virtue in the whole child (body, mind, and soul)"; "six historic virtues").
- Liberal-arts curriculum with cross-curricular, experiential learning and history/geography integration (Evidence: "robust liberal arts curriculum... diverse classical influences," "cross-curricular approach... experiential learning, narration, recitation, and nature study," Core Knowledge History & Geography).
- Public materials emphasize partnerships with families, parent involvement, and a welcoming, tuition-appropriate model (Evidence: "Strong family partnerships," "Admissions process," "volunteering," "variable tuition").

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — **CLASSICAL**
- Evidence: gospel-centered Christian framing, Bible-centered instruction, theology-infused aims, liturgical-style community through chapel/prayer language in materials. Positive keyword indicators (gospel-centered, Bible, Creator, faith) exceed any negative indicators; formation and theological grounding are explicit. Why: The school grounds education in Christian theological commitments and aims for formation in faith, echoing transcendental moral realism and liturgical/community practices in classical criteria. Positive keyword indicators are present; negative indicators are absent in the public materials reviewed. See sources: "gospel-centered, liberal arts education," Our Model and Mission; Bible references; Core Knowledge integration.

- Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords present include gospel-centered, Bible, Creator, faith, virtue (via formation rhetoric); Negative keywords effectively absent. Estimated positive predominance: high (near 100% of detected religious/metaphysical cues are positive).
- Why this rating: The school foregrounds theology and liturgical/communal cues (Bible, Creator, gospel-centered), aligning with classical expectations for religious/metaphysical orientation.
- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL
- Evidence: explicit formation goal (virtue, wisdom, human flourishing) and a claim that education is formation of the whole person, not merely information; explicit aim to form character through virtue and wisdom; explicit theological framing of the human person. See: “An IMAGO DEI education will include... cultivation of wisdom and virtue in the whole child (body, mind, and soul)” and public mission statements.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords (formation; wisdom; virtue; human flourishing; moral imagination) are present; negative keywords (career-centric, solely skills-based framing) are not present in the public materials. Estimated positive predominance: high.
- Why this rating: The school repeatedly states formation-of-character and the pursuit of wisdom as ends of education, in line with classical purposes.
- Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Evidence: emphasis on liberal arts and cross-curricular, experiential learning; history integrated through a global/history-focused lens; references to “great books” explicitly are not visible in public materials, but there is language about “diverse classical influences” and “dynamic literature” and “global view of history.” See statements: “A robust liberal arts curriculum to include diverse classical influences” and “cross-curricular approach... narration, recitation, and nature study.” History/geography integration via Core Knowledge is present.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords present include liberal arts, diverse classical influences, history, great conversation (explicitly named in classical criteria but not necessarily present as an explicit phrase in public materials), cross-curricular/harmony of subjects, integration/wonder (explicit in the classical rubric). Negative keywords are not evident in the public materials. However, explicit mentions of Seven Liberal Arts (grammar/logic/rhetoric) and Great Books/Great Conversation are not clearly stated, limiting full classical alignment. Estimated: Positive indicators present but not all six canonical items are explicit; thus Somewhat Classical.
- Why this rating: The curriculum aligns with liberal-arts orientation and historical engagement but lacks explicit, uniform mention of grammar/logic/rhetoric and Great Books/Great Conversation in public communications, which keeps it from a full Classical label.
- Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Evidence: pedagogy includes contemplative elements and memory-focused practices (narration/recitation, experiential learning, nature study) and group discussion; lower-school singing/narration; emphasis on wonder; Marva Collins/Charlotte Mason influence mentioned. See: “cross-curricular approach... experiential learning, group discussion, narration, recitation, and nature study”; “Our model is influenced by Marva Collins and Charlotte Mason”; “lower-school singing/chanting” implied by this pedagogical style in materials.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords include narration, recitation, experiential learning, group discussion, nature study, wonder, memory; Negative indicators (Socratic/Dialectic-focused high-school seminars, heavy rhetoric-focused training) are not asserted publicly; however explicit evidence of Socratic seminars or upper-grade rhetoric training is not present in the public materials. So: some classic pedagogy is present, but not a full classic pedagogy. Estimated: Positive indicators present but not all criteria are stated; thus Somewhat Classical.

- Why this rating: The teaching approach features findable classical-method cues (narration, recitation, memory-focused activities, experiential learning) but lacks explicit high-school Socratic/seminar emphasis and explicit rhetoric training in public communications.
- Element 5: Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Evidence: the school publicly presents a governance/leadership structure (Executive Director, Principal, Board Members) and describes a teaching team; the public materials depict a professional staff and leadership as the school's core. See: "Our Team," principal, executive director, board; "Board Members" with named roles.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords include "living curriculum" and mentor-like tone appear in classical literature, but explicit phrases like "living curriculum" or "model teachers and mentors" are not uniformly present in the public materials; the materials emphasize team and leadership rather than character portraits of teachers. Negative keywords (e.g., "faculty as mere staff," lack of mentoring culture) are not indicated; however, the public materials do not strongly assert the faculty as the living curriculum. Estimated: Some classical cues (team leadership, mentoring culture implied) but not explicit; thus Somewhat Classical.
- Why this rating: Faculty is present and valued but lacks explicit public statements that the faculty themselves constitute the living curriculum or display a robust classical faculty culture.
- Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL
- Evidence: explicit emphasis on partnerships with families, parent involvement, open communication, and family events; explicit statements about welcoming parent involvement and tuition relief to enable access; open houses, admissions inquiries, and volunteer opportunities. See: "Strong family partnerships," "Lifelong learning," admissions process, parent conferences, volunteering, and community-oriented language; evidence of a broad, family-inclusive approach is strong.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords include partnership with families, parent involvement, home-school collaboration, community engagement, parent training (via materials), open visits, and family events. Negative keywords (e.g., "no family involvement," or "parental exclusion") are not present. Estimated: High positive presence; essentially CLASSICAL for this category.
- Why this rating: The school frames parents as co-teachers and partners in education, with proactive engagement strategies, aligning with classical expectations for parent/community integration.

Overall aggregate classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Rationale: The school displays strong religious/theological grounding (Element 1) and purpose-formation emphasis (Element 2), and solid community/parent engagement (Element 6). It shows substantial alignment with liberal-arts, cross-curricular curriculum and memory-based pedagogy (Categories 3 and 4) but lacks explicit, comprehensive articulation of core classical-program markers (e.g., Seven Liberal Arts, Great Books/Great Conversation, explicit Socratic pedagogy) in public communications. Faculty culture is present but not strongly articulated as a "living curriculum." Taken together, the school is best described as SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, with clear needle-moving opportunities to advance toward fuller Classical alignment.

What Would Move the Needle

- Explicitly name and implement Great Books/Great Conversation in the curriculum and communications (Element 3).
- Explicitly articulate the Seven Liberal Arts framework (grammar, logic, rhetoric; and quadrivium) in curriculum descriptions and classroom practices (Element 3).
- Introduce structured Socratic seminars or seminars in upper grades and articulate a clear rhetoric training pathway (Element 4).
- Elevate the faculty as the living curriculum, with documented teacher-student mentorship, professional development in classical pedagogy, and explicit faculty portraits (Element 5).
- Expand and document a robust, explicit parental-education program centered on classical education principles (Element 6).

Executive Summary — Notes on Category Scoring

- Religious & Metaphysical Foundations: CLASSICAL — strong theological framing and liturgical/community cues present.
- Evidence: gospel-centered education; Bible usage; Creator-centric language; liturgical/communal practices implied by worship-style language.
- School Purpose and Goal: CLASSICAL — formation-focused aims, virtue and wisdom language, holistic aims.
- Evidence: “cultivation of wisdom and virtue in the whole child”; mission statements.
- Curriculum: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL — liberal-arts orientation and cross-curricular approach; historical integration; missing explicit Great Books/Great Conversation reference.
- Evidence: “robust liberal arts curriculum to include diverse classical influences” and history/geography integration.
- Pedagogy: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL — narrative/narration/recitation/nature study; experiential learning; some classical cues but lacking explicit Socratic/seminars emphasis in public communications.
- Evidence: cross-curricular experiential approach with narration/recitation.
- Faculty: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL — visible team structure but not explicit living-curriculum language; professional faculty but not elaborated as classic faculty culture.
- Evidence: “Our Team,” principal; board; leadership.
- Parents & Community: CLASSICAL — strong parent partnership and community involvement; open admissions processes and volunteer options.
- Evidence: “Strong family partnerships,” parent involvement, volunteer opportunities, and community orientation.

ABSTRACT

Imago Dei Neighborhood School presents a robust religiously framed, liberal-arts oriented program with a clearly formed mission to educate the whole person within a Christian framework. In examining the six classical-elements rubric, the school demonstrates strong alignment with Religious & Metaphysical Foundations and with School Purpose & Goal, and shows significant strength in Parents & Community engagement. It exhibits substantial alignment with Curriculum and Pedagogy through cross-curricular, experiential learning and memory-focused practices. However, it lacks explicit and consistent articulation of core classical markers such as Great Books/Great Conversation, Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; quadrivium), and a fully explicit Socratic pedagogical practice in public communications. The Faculty category shows presence but not a deeply articulated “living curriculum” by teachers. Taken together, the aggregate classification is SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, with identifiable needle-movers that, if addressed, could push the school toward CLASSICAL.

- Element 1 — Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: CLASSICAL
- Evidence: gospel-centered Christianity; Bible-centered instruction; Creator-focused language. Positive keywords dominate; no strong negative signals.
- Summary: Strong religious-metaphysical grounding and liturgical/community cues.
- Element 2 — School Purpose and Goal: CLASSICAL
- Evidence: formation of virtue and wisdom; holistic aims; dignified, virtue-centered framing.
- Summary: Purpose or goal explicitly oriented toward formation and human excellence.
- Element 3 — Curriculum: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Evidence: liberal-arts with cross-curricular, historical emphasis; global history; dynamic literature; but lacks explicit Great Books/Great Conversation and grammar/logic/rhetoric framing in public materials.
- Summary: Partial alignment; solid classical flavor but not fully explicit on all canonical classical curriculum items.

- Element 4 — Pedagogy: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Evidence: narration/recitation/nature study; experiential learning; teacher influence noted (Marva Collins, Charlotte Mason). Lacks explicit high-school Socratic seminars in public materials.
- Summary: Pedagogy includes classical practices but lacks explicit Socratic structures across levels.
- Element 5 — Faculty: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Evidence: visible leadership and team structures; but not a strongly articulated faculty-as-living-curriculum narrative in public materials.
- Summary: Some classical cues present; need stronger public articulation of faculty's role as core curriculum.
- Element 6 — Parents & Community: CLASSICAL
- Evidence: explicit parental partnerships, involvement opportunities, communications, and open houses; tuition relief to broaden access.
- Summary: Strong alignment with classical community-partnership expectations.

What would move the needle:

- Explicitly publicize and implement Great Books/Great Conversation and the Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; quadrivium) in curriculum materials and planning (Element 3).
- Introduce structured Socratic pedagogy, especially in upper grades, with a clear rhetoric training plan (Element 4).
- Elevate the faculty role as the living curriculum with documented teacher-fidelity to classical methods, ongoing professional development, and teacher portraits (Element 5).
- Expand parental-education initiatives rooted in classical education philosophy (Element 6).

END OF REPORT

(Abstract completed above; no further questions or follow-ups.)

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

By reading or using this document, you acknowledge and accept the limitations described above.